

Agreement by proxy^{*}

Norvin Richards

norvin@mit.edu

September, 2026

Consider a case in which multiple heads in the clausal spine appear to agree with the same DP:

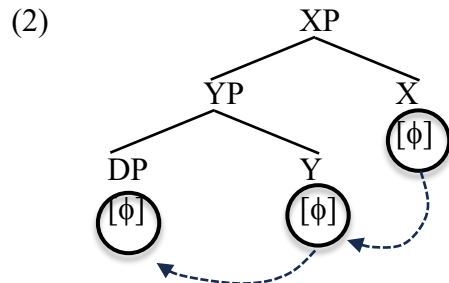
- (1) Raam-ne [roṭii khaa-nii] caah-ii

Raam-ERG bread.**FEM** eat-INF.**FEM.SG** want-PERF.**FEM.SG**

'Raam wanted to eat bread'

[*Hindi-Urdu*, Mahajan 1989, 237]

In (1), both the matrix verb *caahii* 'want' and the embedded infinitival verb *khaanii* 'eat' bear feminine singular agreement morphology, reflecting the properties of *roṭii* 'bread'. A substantial literature on examples like (1) (including Butt 1993, 1995, Bhatt 2005, Legate 2005, Baker and Willie 2010, among others) makes use of the idea that a ϕ -probe can Agree, not just with a DP, but also with another ϕ -probe which has previously Agreed with a DP:



In a Minimalist approach to agreement, in which Agree involves the copying of features from a Goal to a Probe, the Agree relation between Y and DP in (2) creates two copies of the ϕ -features of the DP, one on the DP and the other on Y. There is no particular reason for the ϕ -probe on X

^{*} I am very grateful to the elders who have taught us about the Passamaquoddy language, particularly Margaret Apt, Edwina Mitchell, Grace Paul, and Roger Paul. Thanks, too, to David Pesetsky, Peter Grishin, the Passamaquoddy Reading Group, and audiences at MIT, Boston University, and the Chicago Linguistic Society for helpful comments and suggestions. Responsibility for all the remaining errors is entirely mine.

not to be able to Agree with either of these, in principle. In fact, depending on our assumptions about locality of Agree, we might expect that YP is closer to X than the DP is, and hence a preferable target for Agree by X.

Bhatt (2005) argues that the agreement pattern in (1) involves something like the Agree relations in (2). One of his arguments is based on the fact that if the lower verb fails to Agree with its object, the higher verb cannot Agree with it either:

- (3) a. Raam-ne [roṭii khaa-naa] caah-aa
 Raam-ERG bread.FEM eat-INF.MASC.SG want-PERF.MASC.SG
 'Raam wanted to eat bread'
- b. * Raam-ne [roṭii khaa-naa] caah-ii
 Raam-ERG bread.FEM eat-INF.MASC.SG want-PERF.FEM.SG
 'Raam wanted to eat bread' [*Hindi-Urdu*: Bhatt and Keine 2017]¹

Bhatt concludes that the ϕ -probes responsible for agreement morphology on the matrix verb are too far from the embedded object to Agree with it, but are close enough to the ϕ -probes responsible for agreement morphology on the embedded verb; consequently, the higher verb can only reflect the ϕ -features of the object if those features appear on the embedded verb.

Legate (2005), in her work on the configuration in (2), names the relationship between the higher head and the DP *Cyclic Agreement*. I think this name is now confusingly close to *Cyclic Agree* (Rezac 2003, Béjar and Rezac 2009, and much other work), so at the risk of introducing even more confusion, in this paper I will refer to the phenomenon as *Agreement by proxy*. In (2), I'll say that X Agrees *directly* with Y, and Agrees with the DP *by proxy*.

¹ Interestingly, the fourth logically possible pattern, in which the lower verb Agrees with the object and the higher verb does not, is a point of cross-speaker variation; some speakers (including Bhatt) reject such examples, while others accept them.

One general principle which will be useful in what follows (a version of which, I think, is also part of Legate's (2005) take on this general idea) is the following:

(4) *Agreement by Proxy is Agreement*

The syntactic and morphological consequences of a Probe-Goal relation between A and B can take place if A Agrees with B either *directly* or *by proxy*.

For example, it will turn out to be useful to think that if an Agree relation between A and B would trigger movement of B to A, then this movement can be triggered even if A Agrees with B only by proxy, and not directly. One way to think of this would be as a claim about the triggers for movement operations; movement is not triggered by Agree, per se, we might think, but by configurations in which certain features of B appear on A (and these configurations can be created by Agree, either directly or by proxy)².

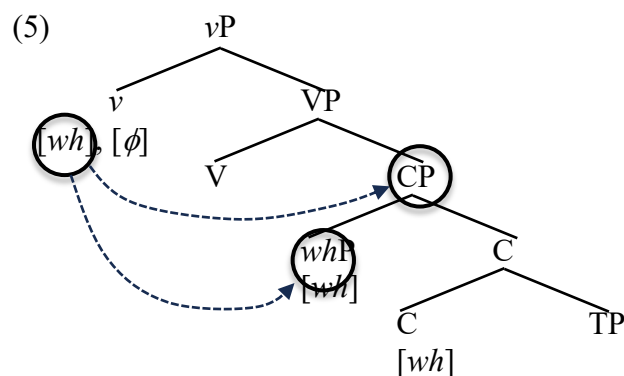
In the next section, I will show how these ideas can give us a new understanding of the phenomenon of 'phase unlocking', and begin the construction of a new approach to the ban on improper movement. Section 2 applies the approach to some facts about long-distance agreement in Passamaquoddy-Wolastoqey, and completes the account of improper movement. Section 3 reviews the assumptions about locality which are necessary for the account to work, section 4 and section 5 concludes.

1. Phase unlocking

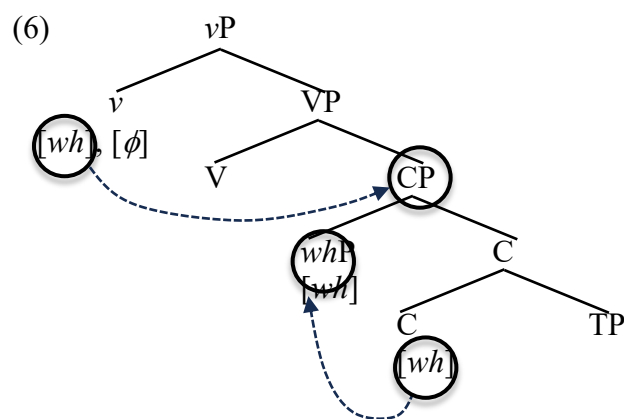
It has been argued that extraction from a phase requires that the phase be 'unlocked' (Rackowski and Richards 2005, Preminger 2011, van Urk and Richards 2015, Halpert 2019, Lee and Yip 2021, Thivierge 2021, Hedding and Yuan 2023). On this view, wh-extraction from CP, for

² As David Pesetsky (p.c.) points out to me, the idea in (4) is also reminiscent of Baker's (1988) Government Transparency Corollary.

example, requires that the wh-probe on v first Agree with the CP to be extracted from, after which it can Agree with the wh-phrase itself:



If it is true that *Agreement by Proxy is Agreement*, then an alternative approach to phase unlocking suggests itself. We might imagine that phases cannot in fact be 'unlocked'; they are impenetrable to the (direct) Agree relation. But since the wh-probe on v Agrees with the CP, and C Agrees with the wh-phrase, v can Agree with the wh-phrase *by proxy*, despite the impenetrability of the phase:

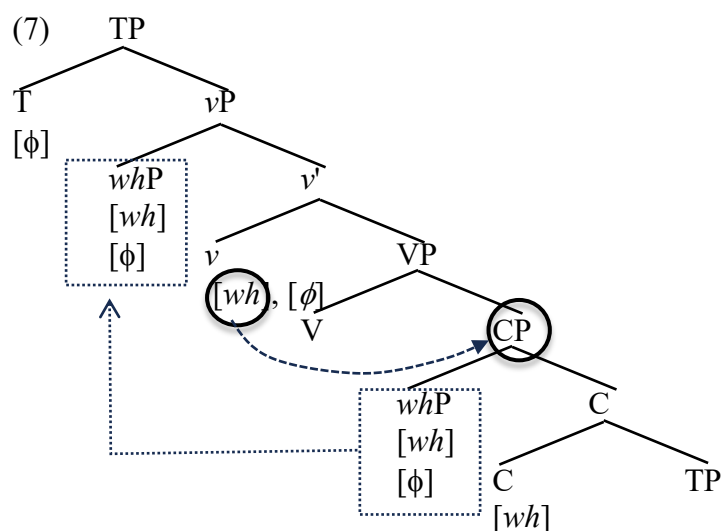


The relationship of *Agreement by proxy* between the wh-probe on v and the wh-phrase can then trigger wh-movement out of CP.

We can see one reason to think of phase unlocking in this way if we consider the behavior of the ϕ -probe on v . This probe is like the wh-probe on v , in that it is in a position to Agree with the CP. We standardly assume that C may have a wh-probe triggering movement into its

specifier, but that C does not bear a ϕ -probe in a language like English. In other words, the ϕ -probe on v may be able to Agree *directly* with the ϕ -features of CP, if CP bears any such features, but will not be able to Agree *by proxy* with the wh-phrase. As a result, the wh-phrase will be able to move out of CP via the type of movement triggered by wh-probes (A-bar movement), but not via the type of movement triggered by ϕ -probes (A-movement). A-movement out of CP is banned, and A-bar movement out of CP is allowed, not because of stipulations about the locality conditions on these movements, or because of an appeal to a ban on improper movement (Chomsky 1973, 1981), but because C itself Agrees with the phrase in its specifier with a wh-probe, and not with a ϕ -probe, and the only way to extract elements out of the CP phase is by Agreeing with them by proxy. For one paper arguing that it is indeed the case that languages can have A-movement out of CP just if C bears a ϕ -probe, see Fong (2019).

Although this approach to phase unlocking successfully rules out A-movement out of CP in a language like English, it is not yet a complete account of the ban on improper movement. Consider the next stage in a derivation involving A-bar movement of a wh-phrase out of a CP to the specifier of the v P of the higher clause:



Here the wh-probe on v , by Agreeing directly with CP, Agrees by proxy with the wh-phrase, triggering wh-movement to the specifier of vP . Suppose the next head to Merge is T, which bears a ϕ -probe. At this point, it is not clear what would prevent the ϕ -probe on T from Agreeing with the wh-phrase, if the wh-phrase has a ϕ -feature of its own. In other words, we have derived the result that movement out of CP must be A-bar movement, but unless we are to stipulate a ban on improper movement, it seems as though the wh-phrase ought to be able to undergo A-movement as the next step of the derivation.

I will end this section with this important issue, and turn to Passamaquoddy-Wolastoqey (which I will refer to from now on as Passamaquoddy, since most of the data discussed here will be from Passamaquoddy speakers). The facts of Passamaquoddy will give us evidence for a version of the same question, and will also point in the direction of a particular kind of answer to the puzzle. We will see that what we need, in both cases, is to restrict Agree by T so that T can Agree only with those DPs with which v has already Agreed; that is, we will see that T can Agree with the DPs in vP only by proxy, and not directly.

2. Passamaquoddy

I will start this section by introducing some facts about Passamaquoddy. In particular, we will take a brief look at the Passamaquoddy agreement system (and I will try to highlight the parts of this system which will be important for us later), and at the nature of clausal complementation in Passamaquoddy.

2.1 Passamaquoddy agreement

The first thing to note about agreement morphology on the Passamaquoddy verb is that there is quite a lot of it:

their distribution. Briefly, these are two distinct patterns of inflection for the verb, the distribution of which is syntactically conditioned; the Independent order may be thought of as the default, while the Conjunct order is used, for example, in relative clauses, some but not all *wh*-questions, certain types of embedded clauses (including some complement clauses, and also adjuncts which would be introduced in English with words like *if* and *when*), and certain exclamations. One main morphological difference between Independent and Conjunct verbs has to do with the particular morphemes used for agreement:

- (10) a. Kt-atkuhkew-ol-pon
 2-tell.story_{TA}-2OBJ-1PL
 ‘We tell you a story’
- b. Atkuhkew-ol-ek
 tell.story_{TA}-2OBJ-1PL.CJ
 ‘if we tell you a story...’

The Conjunct verb in (10b) has the same verb stem and object agreement suffix as the Independent verb in (10a), but lacks the Independent verb’s agreement prefix, and has a morphologically distinct agreement suffix, marked with CJ in the gloss. Throughout, I will gloss verbs as I have above, glossing agreement morphemes which are specific to Conjunct verbs, and leaving Independent verbs unmarked.

Again, the most important piece of information in (9) is just the fact that there are multiple ϕ -probes in the Passamaquoddy clausal spine, each with its own particular preferences for elements to agree with. If there is a second piece of evidence that would be worth bearing in mind, it is the fact in (9c); that Passamaquoddy C bears a ϕ -probe, which can agree with DP *wh*-phrases when these are present (if the verb is Conjunct) (Bruening 2001, 210):

- (11) Wen-il kisi-milakonim-a-htic-il?
 who-OBV PERF-tell.stories.about_{TA}-3OBJ-3PL.CJ-OBV

'Who are they telling stories about?'

Readers may remember that the results of the previous section were connected to the fact that English C lacks a ϕ -probe; now we are learning that Passamaquoddy C in fact has a ϕ -probe. The consequences of this difference will become important soon.

2.2 Propositional clausal complements

Passamaquoddy has a number of kinds of propositional clausal complements. I will outline the properties of three of them below, directing interested readers to Grishin (2023a) for further discussion.

2.2.1 Propositional clausal complements with agreement:

'kocicihtun 'know', wewitahatomon 'remember'...

The largest class of propositional-complement-taking verbs in Passamaquoddy are inflected as though they were transitive verbs with inanimate objects. Consider the Passamaquoddy examples in (12):

- (12) a. N-kociciy-a
 1-know_{TA}-3OBJ
 'I know about him'
- b. N-kocicihtu-n
 1-know_{TI}-INAN
 'I know it'
- c. Mam-ote n-kocicihtu-n [eli-ahcuwi-'ci-maciyuti yut]
 finally-EMPH 1-know_{TI}-INAN IC.that-must-from-away.move.1CJ here
 'I finally knew I had to move away from here'

(<https://pmportal.org/dictionary/ci-c-t>)

There are transitive Passamaquoddy verbs with meanings that are versions of 'know' which can take animate objects (12a) and others which take inanimate objects (12b); without going into detail about the morphology involved, the reader can see that the verbs in (12a-b) are morphologically distinct. When 'know' takes a clausal complement, the form of the verb is the one in (12b), in which it takes an inanimate object. The object of the verb in (12a-b) is arguably a dropped pronoun; in (12c), the verb's object, with which it bears morphological agreement, is apparently the complement clause itself.

2.2.2 Propositional clausal complements without agreement: *itom* 'say', *litahasu* 'think'...

Another, much smaller class of verbs take propositional complements, but do not agree with them; the verbs are morphologically intransitive, agreeing only with their subjects:

(13) a. Piyel litahas-u [kci-wewisosk-u psuwis]

Piyel think_{AI-3} very-be.nosy_{AI-3} cat

'Piyel thinks the cat is very nosy'

(<https://pmportal.org/dictionary/kci-wewisosku>)

b. Itom [psite nit qasahkas-u]

say_{TI-O-3} all that.INAN be.thrown.away_{II-3}

'He said that all of it was thrown away'

(<https://pmportal.org/dictionary/qasahkasu>)

These verbs bear morphology agreeing with their 3rd person subjects, but are unlike the verbs of the previous section in bearing no morphology agreeing with an object.

2.2.3 Propositional complements of ditransitive verbs

A third class of verbs take both a propositional clausal complement and a nominal internal argument. The verbs in question are treated morphologically simply as transitive verbs with animate objects; that is, they agree with their subjects, and with their nominal internal arguments, but not with their complement clauses:

(14) Nt-ahcuwi-mihkuluwem-a Piyel [eli-cuwi-liya-t ihtolokehkitimok]

1-must-remind-3OBJ Piyel IC.that-must-go-3CJ school

'I have to remind Piyel [that he has to go to the school]'

[Edwina Mitchell, p.c. to Peter Grishin, 2023.5.9]

In (14), the verb meaning 'remind' agrees with its subject, and with the object *Piyel*, but there is no agreement with the complement clause⁴.

⁴ There are also Passamaquoddy verbs with an apparently ditransitive argument structure, like the verbs in this section, which Agree both with the nominal object and with the clausal object:

(i) N-messunomu-w-a-n [miyawikon kahk mihkutakon]
1-show_{TA+O-3OBJ-INAN} looks.good_{II} indeed knife

2.2.4 Review of propositional complements

The preceding sections have described three classes of verbs. Most verbs with propositional complements agree with the clausal complement as though it were an inanimate object (*'kocicihtun* 'know', *wewitahatomon* 'remember'...). A few verbs with propositional complements are morphologically intransitive, agreeing only with their subjects (*itom* 'say', *litahasu* 'think'...). And finally, there are verbs that take both nominal and clausal internal arguments which also do not agree with the clausal complement; they agree as though their only arguments were the subject and the nominal internal argument (the example given above was *mihkuluwemal* 'remind').

2.2.5 Propositional complements and *wh*-extraction

As the previous section briefly reviewed, there are Passamaquoddy verbs which agree with their propositional complements, and Passamaquoddy verbs which do not. Here is a generalization about *wh*-extraction from these propositional complements:

(15) If a DP is *wh*-extracted from a propositional complement clause,

and the higher verb would agree with that clause,

the higher verb must agree with the *wh*-phrase instead of the clause.

Let us see some evidence for this generalization, beginning with verbs that do agree with their complement clauses:

'I showed him that it was in fact a good knife' (<https://pmportal.org/dictionary/miyawikon>)
Here the verb *nmessonomuwan* 'I showed it to him' agrees like a ditransitive verb, showing agreement with both the pro-dropped arguments 'I' and 'him', and also with the clausal complement. The following discussion will concentrate largely on the effects extraction can have on the agreement morphology that cross-references clauses. The embedded clause in (i) is agreed with like the direct object of a ditransitive verb, and agreement of this kind is fairly impoverished; in particular, the ϕ -probes on INFL and *v* do not distinguish animate from inanimate objects in this position. This means that verbs like the one in (i) will be largely uninformative with respect to the data to be discussed in the paper, and I will therefore leave them aside in what follows.

- (16) a. Cora *wewitahatom-on*
 Cora *remember_{TI-INAN}*
 [*eli nomiy-a-t Piyel-ol lamiw kcihku-k*].
 IC.that *see_{TA-3OBJ-3CJ}* *Piyel-OBV* *inside* *woods.LOC*
 'Cora remembered that she saw Piyel in the woods' (constructed)
- b. Weni-l Cora *wewitaham-a-t*
 who-OBV Cora *remember_{TA-3OBJ-3CJ}*
 [*eli nomiy-a-t lamiw kcihku-k*?
 IC.that *see_{TA-3OBJ-3CJ}* *inside* *woods.LOC*
 'Who did Cora remember that she saw in the woods?'
 (Grace Paul, p.c., 2023.01.04)
- c. * Weni-l Cora *wewitahato-k*
 who-OBV Cora *remember_{TI-3CJ}*
 [*eli nomiy-a-t lamiw kcihku-k*?
 IC.that *see_{TA-3OBJ-3CJ}* *inside* *woods.LOC*
 'Who did Cora remember that she saw in the woods?'
 (Grace Paul, p.c. to Peter Grishin, 2023.01.04)

In (16a), we see the verb *wewitahatomon* 'remember' agreeing with its complement clause; the verb has the form of a transitive verb with an inanimate object. In (16b), a DP is wh-extracted from the complement clause, and the form of the verb for 'remember' changes; it takes on the form of a verb with an animate object, agreeing with the wh-phrase *wenil* 'who-OBV' as if the wh-phrase were its direct object. In (16c), we can see that this change in the form of the verb is

obligatory; 'remember' can no longer bear the morphology of a verb with an inanimate object, as it did in (16a).

The other two types of CP-complement-taking verbs described above do not agree with their clausal complements. And as we will see, wh-extraction from their clausal complements does not have the effects on the form of the verb that we saw in (16). Consider first verbs like *litahasu* 'think', which inflect as though they were intransitive verbs, agreeing only with their subjects:

- (17) a. Tihtiyas litahas-u [eli-cuwi-mattoktehmuv-a-t Roger-ol]
 Tihtiyas think_{AI-3} IC.that-must-call_{TA-3OBJ-3CJ} Roger-OBV
 'Tihtiyas thinks that she has to call Roger'
- b. Weni-l litahas-u Tihtiyas [eli-cuwi-mattoktehmuv-a-t]?
 who-OBV think_{AI-3} Tihtiyas IC.that-must-call_{TA-3OBJ-3CJ}
 'Who does Tihtiyas think she has to call?'
 (Edwina Mitchell, p.c., 2023.01.04)

In (17a), *litahasu* 'think' bears agreement only with its subject *Tihtiyas*; it has no morphology indicating the presence of an inanimate object. In (17b), we can see that wh-extraction does not change the form of this kind of verb.

In (18), we can see the same kind of fact for the kind of verb which agrees both with a subject and with an animate object, but not with the clausal complement:

- (18) a. N-mihkuluwem-oq eli-cuwi-mattoktehmuh-uk n-uhsimis
 1-remind_{TA}-INV IC.that-must-call_{TA}-1SUBJ3OBJ.CJ 1-y.sibling
 'She reminded me that I had to call my sister'
- b. Wen-il kisi-mihkuluwem-os-k eli-cuwi-mattoktehmoh-ot?
 who-OBV PERF-remind_{TA}-2OBJ-3CJ IC.that-must-call_{TA}-2SUBJ3OBJ.CJ
 'Who did she remind you that you have to call?'
- (Edwina Mitchell, p.c., 2024.10.04)

In (18a), *nmihkuluwemoq* 'she reminded me' agrees both with 'she' and with 'me', but has no morphology indicating the presence of the complement clause. In (17b), we can see that wh-extraction from this kind of complement clause has no effect on the higher verb; the verb is still a simple transitive verb, agreeing with the subject and with its animate object (in this case, 'you').

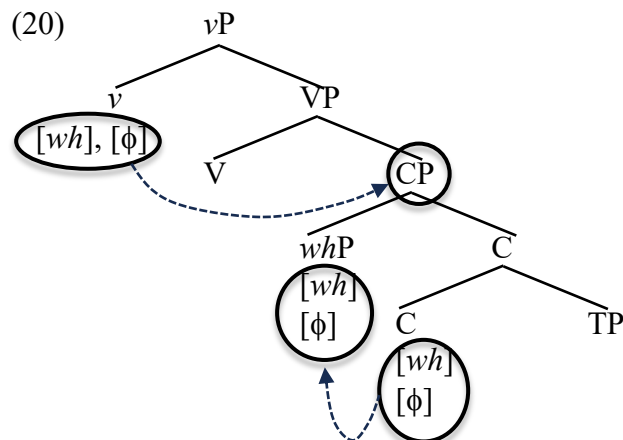
To summarize these facts again; just if a verb agrees morphologically with its complement clause (that is, just in (16), but not in (17) or (18)), if a DP is wh-extracted from the complement clause, the agreement with the complement clause must be replaced by agreement with the wh-phrase.

Now we can return to the idea of Agreement by proxy. Recall that Passamaquoddy C, unlike English C, bears ϕ -feature agreement with its specifier:

- (19) Wen-il kisi-milakonim-a-htic-il?
 who-OBV PERF-tell.stories.about_{TA}-3OBJ-3PL.CJ-OBV
 'Who are they telling stories about?'

In (19), the verb bears a suffix *-il* 'OBV', which agrees morphologically with the obviative wh-phrase in the specifier of CP; for arguments that this suffix is generated in C, see Grishin (2023a) and Oxford (2024).

On the theory outlined in section 1, then, we should expect that if Passamaquoddy *v*, like English *v*, bears *wh*- and ϕ -probes, then in Passamaquoddy (unlike in English), both of these probes should be in a position to Agree by proxy with a DP *wh*-phrase in the specifier of CP:



In (20), both of the probes on Passamaquoddy *v* Agree with the complement CP. Since the C of this CP Agrees with the *wh*-phrase in its specifier both for *[wh]* and for $[\phi]$, the probes on *v* can Agree by proxy with the *wh*-phrase for both *[wh]* and $[\phi]$ as well.

We have seen that Passamaquoddy has some clausal-complement-taking verbs which idiosyncratically do not morphologically agree with their complement clauses. As we have also seen, these are the verbs which do not morphologically agree with the *wh*-phrase when it is extracted. The account in this paper explains why this would be. *No* instance of *v* can Agree directly with a *wh*-phrase in an embedded CP. Agreement with the embedded *wh*-phrase is always Agreement by proxy, and if a particular feature on *v* fails to Agree with the CP, it will not be able to Agree with the *wh*-phrase, either.

The morphological consequences of 'phase unlocking' appear to vary from language to language. In Tagalog (Rackowski and Richards 2005) and Dinka (van Urk and Richards 2015, van Urk 2015), extraction of *wh*-phrases from embedded clauses requires morphological agreement on the higher verb with the embedded clause:

- (21) a. Sino ang p-in-aniwala-an ng magsasaka
 who ANG -ASP-believe-DAT UNM farmer
 [na k-um-ain ng bulaklak]?
 C -ASP.NOM-eat UNM flower
 'Who did the farmer believe ate the flower?' [Tagalog]
- b. Yè kôc-kó [é-ké-yîi Bôl ké luêeel [è é-kè-cèk]?
 be people-which PST-PL-HAB.OY Bol.GEN 3PL say.NF C PST-PL-be.short
 'Which people did Bol think were short?' [Dinka (van Urk 2015, 134)]

In both of these examples, the subject of the complement clause is extracted, but the morphology on the matrix verb cross-references the complement clause itself, not the properties of the extracted phrase. Halpert (2019) argues that raising out of finite CP in Zulu can allow the matrix verb to agree either with the raised nominal or with the complement clause:

- (22) a. uZinhle u-bonakala [ukuthi u-xova ujeqe]
 AUG.1Zinhle 1S-seem that 1S-make AUG.1bread
- a. uZinhle ku-bonakala [ukuthi u-xova ujeqe]
 AUG.1Zinhle 17S-seem that 1S-make AUG.1bread
 'Zinhle seems to be making steamed bread now'

In Passamaquoddy, apparently, we see the other logically possible morphological choice: phase unlocking results in the higher head obligatorily agreeing morphologically with the extracted phrase itself.

Descriptively, there appear to be three morphological options:

(23) If a Probe Agrees directly with X, and by proxy with Y, and Y then moves out of X, the features that the Probe may realize morphologically are:

- a. those of X (Tagalog, Dinka)
- b. those of Y (Passamaquoddy)
- c. those of either X or Y (Zulu)

Whether there are any other properties of the examples in (21-22) which dictate the choice in (23) is a question I will leave for further work⁵.

Agreement with *wh*-phrases is not the only kind of long-distance agreement Passamaquoddy exhibits. I will turn to the more general pattern next, and then return to the *wh*-extraction cases.

2.2.6 Clausal complements without *wh*-extraction

Passamaquoddy long-distance agreement is the subject of a small but lively literature (Bruening 2001, LeSourd 2019, Grishin 2023a). For purposes of this paper I will adopt an analysis of the phenomenon which is comparatively widely held (Bruening 2001, Polinsky and Potsdam 2001, Branigan and MacKenzie 2002, Grishin 2023a)⁶.

In Passamaquoddy, the phenomenon of long-distance agreement appears with the verbs discussed above which agree with their clausal complements. Such verbs also have the option of agreeing with any of the arguments contained in their clausal complements. The sentence in (24) therefore comes in three possible variants, differing only in the form of the matrix verb:

⁵ Van Urk (2015) argues that Dinka C, like Passamaquoddy C, bears a ϕ -probe. If he is right, the presence of a ϕ -probe on C cannot be the factor that determines the choice of options in (23).

⁶ For an alternative analysis of long-distance agreement, see Richards (2026)

- (24) a. '-Kociciy-a-l Piyel [eli k-posum psite
 3-know_{TA}-3OBJ-OBV Piyel IC.that 2-cat all
 noluwitaham-i-nokot]
 feel.safe.with_{TA}-1OBJ-3:1PL.CJ
 'Piyel knows that your cat feels safe with all of us'
 [Grace Paul, p.c. to Peter Grishin, 2023.01.24]
- b. N-kociciy-uku-n Piyel [eli k-posum psite
 1-know_{TA}-INV-1PL Piyel IC.that 2-cat all
 noluwitaham-i-nokot]
 feel.safe.with_{TA}-1OBJ-3:1PL.CJ
 'Piyel knows that your cat feels safe with all of us'
 [Grace Paul, p.c. to Peter Grishin, 2023.01.24]
- c. '-Kocicihtu-n Piyel [eli k-posum psite
 3-know_{TI}-INAN Piyel IC.that 2-cat all
 noluwitaham-i-nokot]
 feel.safe.with_{TA}-1OBJ-3:1PL.CJ
 'Piyel knows that your cat feels safe with all of us'
 [constructed]

The matrix verb in (24) agrees with its subject *Piyel*, and has the option of also agreeing with *your cat*, as in (24a), or with *us*, as in (24b); it can also bear morphology indicating agreement with a singular inanimate object, as in (24c), presumably signalling agreement with the complement clause itself.

In one approach to long-distance agreement in Passamaquoddy and languages with similar phenomena (Bruening 2001, Polinsky and Potsdam 2001, Branigan and MacKenzie 2002, Grishin 2023a), the options in (24) reflect an optional movement operation, which can be covert, and which can move a DP to the left periphery of the embedded clause, rendering it accessible for agreement from the higher clause. In terms of the theory under construction here, we can understand the movement in question as involving a ϕ -probe in the embedded C; once embedded C has Agreed with a DP in the embedded clause, any higher ϕ -probe Agreeing with the embedded C will Agree with the embedded DP by proxy⁷.

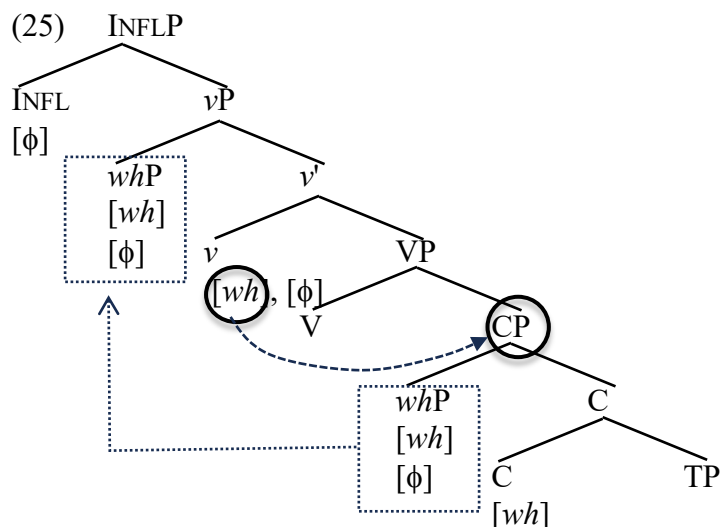
One other note is in order before we move on. It is worth emphasizing that the phenomenon of 'long-distance agreement' involves all of the ϕ -probes in the Passamaquoddy clause. In (24a) above, for example, it is the ϕ -probe on the v of the matrix clause which morphologically realizes agreement with a DP of the embedded clause (via the suffix *-a*, which shows 3rd person agreement with *kposum* 'your cat'). In (24b), it is the ϕ -probe on INFL that shows long-distance agreement, in this case with the pro-dropped 1st person plural argument of the embedded clause; here the relevant affixes are the prefix *n-* '1st person' and the suffix *-n* '1st person plural'. This will be important in the next section: long-distance agreement is realized, not just on v , but also on INFL.

⁷ It may be worth highlighting the fact that the DP with which the matrix v Agrees need not be one which controls agreement morphology on embedded C. In the particular examples in (24), for example, embedded C bears no overt agreement morphology at all, and this situation is compatible with a number of morphological behaviors for matrix v . On the view outlined here, we need to regard embedded C as bearing Agree relations both with the nominals described in (9c) above, with which C may bear morphological agreement, and also with a potentially distinct nominal which undergoes covert movement to the specifier of CP (and which may or may not trigger agreement morphology on C). It is apparently this second Agree relation which provides the feature with which matrix v may Agree.

2.2.7 Back to wh-extraction

Let us now consider extraction of a wh-phrase from the clausal complement of a verb like

litahasu 'think', which does not Agree with its clausal complement:



We have already seen that the v associated with a verb like *litahasu* 'think' bears a ϕ -probe which, idiosyncratically, fails to Agree with the complement CP. The proposal above was that, because the ϕ -probe on v has failed to Agree with CP, it has lost its chance to Agree with the wh-phrase; ϕ -Agreement between v and the wh-phrase, when it occurs, is always Agreement by proxy. The wh-probe on v can Agree with the CP, and by proxy with the wh-phrase, triggering wh-movement out of the CP, but the ϕ -probe on v cannot copy the wh-phrase's ϕ -features. In this regard, this particular type of clausal complement (the one selected by verbs like *litahasu* 'think') is like its English counterpart; the wh-feature on v can Agree with the wh-phrase by proxy, but the ϕ -feature on v cannot.

But now we arrive at the same puzzle for Passamaquoddy that appeared before in the discussion of English. Passamaquoddy is like English in having a ϕ -probe on a head above v in the clausal spine; Grishin (2023) and Oxford (2024) refer to this head as INFL. At the point in the

derivation in (25), even if v 's ϕ -probe cannot Agree with the wh-phrase, what prevents the ϕ -probe on INFL from Agreeing with the wh-phrase?

The fact, for Passamaquoddy, is that ϕ -Agreement on v and on INFL pattern together. If the matrix verb is like *litahasu* 'think', neither v nor INFL may ϕ -Agree with the extracted wh-phrase; for matrix verbs like *'kocicihtun* 'know', both of them do. This was emphasized toward the end of the preceding section, where we saw that the ϕ -probes of the clause all participate in long-distance agreement. In section 1 of the paper, we saw part of this pattern in English; English v cannot ϕ -Agree with an extracted wh-phrase, and neither can T. In both languages, T/INFL can Agree with the wh-phrase just if v also Agrees with it.

We appear to be uncovering another case of Agreement by proxy. In these languages, T/INFL Agrees directly with v P, but not with anything inside v P. Just when v has independently Agreed with a DP, then T/INFL can also Agree with that DP by proxy. What assumptions about the locality of Agree would guarantee this result?

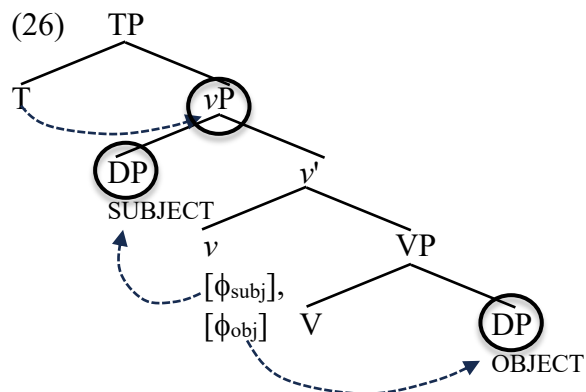
3. Locality and Agreement by proxy

Let us review some of the observations described above, and see if we can assemble them into a theory.

We saw some reasons to think that CP is opaque for probing by v ; v can Agree with elements inside CP only by proxy, Agreeing with any phrases with which C Agrees. This is why CP needs to be 'unlocked' for wh-extraction (Rackowski and Richards 2005, and related work). It is why wh-movement out of CP in a language like English cannot be A-movement, as we saw in section 1. And it is why, in Passamaquoddy, wh-extraction from CP triggers ϕ -agreement with the wh-phrase on the matrix verb, just if that verb would ordinarily morphologically agree with the CP from which extraction takes place.

We have also seen that vP is opaque for probing by English T, and Passamaquoddy INFL. This is why, in both languages, T/INFL can morphologically agree with a wh-phrase moving out of the embedded clause just if v Agrees with the same wh-phrase. As a result, English T can never agree with such wh-phrases (this is the ban on improper movement), and Passamaquoddy INFL can agree with such wh-phrases just in case the lower v has agreed with them.

In other words, T and INFL can Agree with the contents of vP only by proxy, and v can Agree with the contents of CP only by proxy. Taking these ideas seriously, we might start the derivation by allowing v to Agree with all of the DP arguments in the clause (for ideas along these lines, see Richards (1997, pp. 88-97), Clem and Deal (2024), Poole (2024)). Probes on heads outside vP , like English T and Passamaquoddy INFL, Agree with vP itself, and by proxy with the subject and object. I will refer to Passamaquoddy INFL as T from here on, just to simplify the discussion; the tree in (26) is meant to represent both English and Passamaquoddy:



At this point in the derivation, T and v both bear the features of both the subject and the object⁸. The best current accounts of Algonquian agreement (e.g., Oxford (2024)) posit agreement on T with both the subject and the object, but agreement on v only with the object; similarly, English T clearly agrees with the subject, but is not generally thought to agree with the object as well. We

⁸ In ditransitives, we can posit an ApplP which agrees with both objects, and then higher v can agree both with the subject and with ApplP, acquiring the features of all three DP arguments.

could view these morphological facts as the product of impoverishment operations, possibly triggered by the need to make T and v dissimilar. On this view, both Passamaquoddy and English go through a stage of the derivation in which T and v both bear the features of both the subject and the object; in the course of realizing this representation morphologically, Passamaquoddy begins by deleting the subject's features from v , while English deletes the object's features from T⁹.

These assumptions have the consequence that v and T have access to the features of the subject and object of their clause, but that a DP wh-phrase moving through the clause will be accessible for ϕ -agreement only under certain conditions, deriving the generalizations discussed in this paper.

In English, C does not have a ϕ -probe. If CP has a wh-phrase in its specifier, C will have a wh-probe Agreeing with it, but not a ϕ -probe. Consequently, if a higher v attracts the wh-phrase out of the embedded CP, a wh-probe on v will be able to agree by proxy with the wh-phrase, but a ϕ -probe will be unable to agree with the wh-phrase, even if the wh-phrase is a DP. When T is Merged, its ϕ -probe will Agree with v P, and by proxy with any DPs that v has Agreed with; this may include a subject and an object, but will not include a wh-phrase moved out of the lower clause. In other words, wh-movement out of an embedded clause in English may not participate in A-movement in the higher clause; this is the ban on improper movement.

In Passamaquoddy, C does bear a ϕ -probe, which will Agree with a DP wh-phrase moved to its specifier. When a wh-phrase moves into a higher clause, its ϕ -features may be accessible to

⁹ As Peter Grishin points out to me, this raises interesting questions about other kinds of patterns we might hope to find in the world's languages. In particular, as he notes, we might imagine that morphologically ergative languages are the ones in which the subject's features are preferentially deleted from T; these would then be languages in which objects, when present, typically controlled agreement on the highest probe on the clause, which does seem to be a plausible description of morphological ergativity.

agreement by higher probes. As we have seen, some Passamaquoddy verbs combine with a version of v that can ϕ -Agree with a complement clause, and others with a version of v that cannot¹⁰. Just when v Agrees with CP, it is in a position to Agree by proxy with a DP wh-phrase in the specifier of CP, and these ϕ -features will then be available to the ϕ -probe on T.

These claims about the distribution of opacity for Agree, then, seem to get us desirable results. What theory of locality would guarantee that the relevant phrases are opaque in the relevant ways?

3.1 Locality for T and v

For most of the Agree relations discussed in this paper, a very traditional approach to locality, along the lines of Relativized Minimality, would be sufficient:

- (27) a. A probe P cannot Agree with a goal G if another goal G' is *closer* to P than G is.
 b. If α c-commands β , then β is closer to α than γ is if every node dominating β dominates γ .

(27a) requires a probe to Agree with a goal which is at least as close to it as any other goal.

(27b) defines *closer* in such a way that one goal is closer than the other if the first goal c-commands or dominates the second.

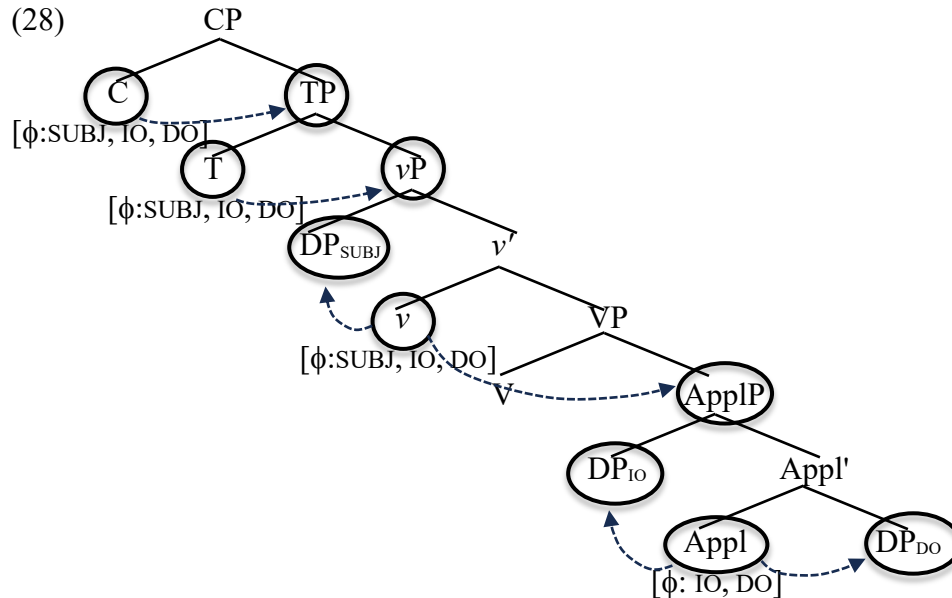
These definitions will have the consequence, for example, that when a ϕ -feature on T seeks a Goal, the closest Goal it will find will be vP ; at this point in the derivation, vP dominates all the DPs in the clause, and the ϕ -feature on vP , which Agrees with the clause's arguments, is therefore the closest one to T. Similarly, a ϕ -probe on v which seeks to Agree with the interior of CP will first encounter the ϕ -features of the CP itself, and since the CP dominates its interior, the

¹⁰ Alternatively, it may be that every instance of v is the same, and that the complement clauses differ structurally in ways that allow or forbid agreement. I return to this possibility in the next footnote.

ϕ -probe will be compelled to Agree with CP. The same ϕ -probe will be able to Agree with the subject and the object of its own clause, perhaps via Cyclic Agree (Béjar and Rezac 2009 and much other work).

A simple, traditional version of locality, then, seems to be enough to get the majority of the results discussed so far. Probing is in general very local, and apparent violations of this locality are the result of agreement by proxy.

The resulting Probe-Goal relations involving ϕ -probes would then run as follows, for a sentence involving a ditransitive verb:



Each probe in (28) finds Goals that obey the locality condition in (27). The ϕ -probe on the Appl head acquires the features of both objects, via Cyclic Agree. The ϕ -probe on v Agrees directly with ApplP, and thereby Agrees by proxy with both objects; it also Agrees with the subject in its specifier. The features of the DPs in the clause are then passed to T, which Agrees with them by proxy, via direct Agree with v P. Finally, the ϕ -probe on C Agrees with TP, again Agreeing by proxy with all three of the DPs.

The tree in (28) is for Passamaquoddy, but the corresponding English tree would differ only in the lack of a ϕ -probe on C. In both languages, the Agree relations pictured have the consequence of restricting the DPs with which verbs may morphologically agree. A DP *wh*-moved from a lower clause into the clause in (28), for example, would be able to participate in ϕ -agreement only if the heads of the clause had been able to acquire its ϕ -features by proxy, by Agreeing with the embedded CP out of which the *wh*-phrase had moved. As we saw above, this never happens in English, and in Passamaquoddy, it happens just when the matrix verb is of the type to ϕ -agree with its complement CP. This difference between English and Passamaquoddy follows, ultimately, from the presence of a ϕ -probe on C in Passamaquoddy, and its absence in English.

English and Passamaquoddy also differ, of course, in how the various ϕ -features on the heads in the tree in (28) can be morphologically realized. English discards most of these ϕ -features, realizing only the highest set of features found on T (that is, those of the subject). Passamaquoddy *v* discards its highest set of features, and realizes agreement in Person with the highest remaining set, if that set is from an animate DP. The features on Passamaquoddy T are realized in several different morphemes, reflecting calculations involving the highest two sets of features on T (those of the subject and the highest object). The ϕ -features on C can also be realized in Passamaquoddy, and we turn to those next.

3.2 Locality for C

Thanks to Grishin's (2023a, 2023b, to appear) work, we know that in clauses in the Independent order, the ϕ -probe on C exhibits morphological agreement with the structurally lowest 3rd person DP in its clause. In the tree in (28) above, for example, C can realize morphological agreement with the direct object. The tree in (28) represents a hypothesis about how C acquires the features

in question; it gets them by Agreeing with TP, which bears features that it has in turn gotten from ν P. We therefore expect C to be able to Agree just with the kinds of phrases that ν could end up with the features of, given the proposals in this paper.

One argument that this conclusion is correct has to do with the treatment of CP complements. We will see that the two kinds of CP complements described above—the kind which are agreed with by their selecting verbs, and the kind which are not—are treated differently, not only by ν , as we saw above, but also by C.

For verbs that agree with their clausal complements, the C of the selecting verb treats the clausal complement as though it were an inanimate singular nominal, agreeing preferentially with it:

(29) 'Kocicihtu-ni-ya-Ø [eli- nutuw-ut.]

3-know-N-~1PL-INAN.SG IC.that- hear-PASS.CJ

'They know that they will be heard' [adapted from

<https://pmportal.org/dictionary/nokolal>]

In (29), the matrix verb *'kocicihtuniya* 'they know it' is of the type which agrees with its complement clause. There are 3rd person plural null pronouns in both the matrix and the embedded clause (translated as *they*). But neither of these animate plurals controls the form of matrix C, which is null, as appropriate for agreement with an inanimate singular. Matrix C in (29), in other words, agrees neither with the subject of its own clause nor with anything in the embedded clause; its 3rd person target is the embedded clause itself.

We have seen, in section 2.2.6 above, that a verb like the one in the matrix clause of (29) has the option of participating in long-distance agreement. What examples like (29) remind us of is just that long-distance agreement is optional: Grishin is right that C Agrees with the lowest 3rd

person nominal, but it is specifically the lowest 3rd person nominal *within its clause* that it must enter into the syntactic relation of Agree with. Moreover, the embedded clause can apparently count as such a nominal.

Verbs that do not agree with the complement clause, by contrast, agree with the lowest 3rd person DP in their own clause, treating the complement clause as though it were invisible:

- (30) Litahas-ultu-w-ok [eli [tehpu nekomaw pawatom-uhstit]
 think_{AI}-PL-3-PROX.PL IC.that only they want-3PL.CJ
 nit=te-hc nt-olluhka-n]
 that=FOC-FUT 1-do-N

'They think that just because they want it I will do it'

[<https://pmportal.org/dictionary/litahasu>]

In (30), matrix C shows morphological agreement with the 3rd person subject of its own clause, displaying proximate plural agreement. In this case, the requirement that C Agree with the structurally lowest 3rd person nominal in its clause is trivially satisfied; the matrix clause contains only one accessible DP, since the complement clause selected by this kind of matrix verb is (exceptionally) not available for Agreement.

There is a third type of clausal embedding which I have not yet mentioned, involving what are referred to in the literature as Subordinative verbs:

- (31) Piyel 't-oqeci-kiseht-uw-a-n Koles-ol ['-sukolopan-ka-li-n]
 Piyel 3-try-make-APPL_{TA+O}-3OBJ-N Grace-OBV 3-cake-make_{AI}-OBV-N
 'Piyel tried to get Gracie to make a cake'

(Grace Paul and Margaret Apt, p.c. to Peter Grishin, 2023.5.2)

The bracketed clause in (31) features a verb in the Subordinative form. I will refer interested parties to Grishin (2023a) for a detailed discussion of the morphological, syntactic, and distributional properties of Subordinatives. Briefly, they morphologically resemble Independent verbs, but invariably lack the morphology that is associated with C.

Grishin (2023a) argues, in fact, that Subordinative clauses lack a CP layer. I will again direct readers to his work, but two of his arguments come from the fact that the agreement morphology that should be in C is absent in Subordinatives, and the fact that Subordinatives, at least for most speakers, cannot be *wh*-questions—that is, they cannot host the left-peripheral material that we associate with the CP layer.

Subordinative clauses are like embedded CPs, however, in that they are treated by matrix C as a third person argument, and therefore a potential Goal for agreement. In (31), for example, matrix C Agrees with the embedded clause itself, and therefore bears null agreement. It is not required to Agree with the subject of the embedded clause; this subject is obviative (as the penultimate agreement morpheme *-li* reveals), and matrix C does not bear the obviative agreement suffix *-il*¹¹.

The remaining puzzle is how to make sure that C's search for 3rd person nominals cannot reach into a complement clause. As things stand, we expect the ϕ -features of the arguments of the clause to be copied onto *v*, and from there onto T, and from there onto C. If the resulting CP (or TP, in the case of a Subordinative clause) is the complement of a verb, what is to prevent matrix *v* from Agreeing with the highest projection of the embedded clause, and acquiring all of

¹¹ We have seen that complement CPs can sometimes be agreed with by higher verbs, and sometimes not. This seems not to be the case for Subordinative clauses, which are always visible for agreement. Perhaps this is a reason to attribute the idiosyncratic properties of certain CPs to the CP layer itself (rather than, for example, to properties of the selecting verb); Subordinative clauses, following Grishin, have no CP layer, and therefore can never have the kind of C which is apparently invisible to Agree.

the phi-features of all of the arguments of the embedded clause? The question is particularly salient, in light of Grishin's generalization that Passamaquoddy Independent C shows morphological agreement with the structurally lowest 3rd person DP that it Agrees with. If we do not prevent C of a matrix clause from routinely copying ϕ -features from C of the embedded clause, then matrix C will be compelled to Agree with the lowest 3rd person DP, not just in its own clause, but in the complement clause as well.

One property that Subordinative TPs and complement CPs have in common, which distinguishes them from the other projections in the clausal spine, is that the agreement system treats them as Goals themselves; as we have seen, verbs agree with both of these types of embedded clauses as though they were inanimate singular nominals.

In section 2.2.5 above, I reviewed the morphology of 'phase unlocking' in several languages. We saw that derivations in which a higher head Agrees directly with a clause, and by proxy with some phrase α inside the clause, and which trigger movement of α out of the embedded clause, vary in their morphological consequences from language to language; some languages (like Tagalog and Dinka) show morphological agreement on the higher head with the clause itself, while others (like Passamaquoddy) agree with the moved α , and still others (Zulu) can allow either option.

Now we are faced with a similar but distinct derivation. What happens when v Agrees with an embedded CP or TP which is itself a possible Goal for ϕ -agreement, and which allows v in principle to Agree by proxy with various DPs inside the embedded clause? What we are apparently seeing is that this configuration results in v agreeing only with the embedded CP or TP, and not with any of the DPs inside it. We could think of this as a preference for features acquired by Direct Agree, over features acquired by Agree by proxy, when both kinds of features

are potentially available (though, as we have seen, this preference is overridden in Passamaquoddy when the result of the Agree operation is to be movement of a phrase out of the clause containing it). Whether this preference is like the morphological consequences of 'phase unlocking' in varying cross-linguistically is a question I will leave for future work¹².

We now appear to be in a position to account for the general behavior of the ϕ -probe on C. What about the wh-probe?

3.3 Locality and morphological coarseness

In section 2.1 above I mentioned that Passamaquoddy C shows distinct morphological agreement patterns in two morphologically distinct kinds of verbs, referred to by Algonquianists as the Conjunct and Independent forms. The preceding section has concentrated on the behavior of C in Independent clauses, which typically do not feature wh-movement of DPs; in such clauses, as we have seen, following Grishin (2023a, 2023b, to appear), C agrees morphologically with the structurally lowest 3rd person DP in its search domain (and the search domain for its ϕ -Probe can stop, as the theory developed so far predicts, at TP, which is the closest ϕ -bearing potential Goal for C). Let us now consider the effects of wh-movement of DPs, which will often trigger the use of the Conjunct form of the verb.

Conjunct C is unlike Independent C in preferentially agreeing with DP wh-phrases when these are present. The naturally occurring example in (32) demonstrates:

¹² We could account for long-distance agreement by allowing phrases to move out of the embedded clause, in ways which make them accessible to Agree by clauses in higher heads. I leave this possibility aside for the moment.

(32) Wen yuhtol tepelom-a-t cikonih-il?

who this.OBV IC.own_{TA}-3OBJ-3CJ apple-OBV

'Whose apple is this?' (literally: 'Who owns this apple?')

(modified from <https://pmportal.org/node/1646>)

If this were an ordinary statement, C would agree with the object, which is the lowest 3rd person nominal in the clause. In (32), this is not what is happening; if it were, C would take the Obviative form. Instead, C agrees with the subject, apparently because the subject is a DP wh-phrase (and is therefore null, which is the appropriate form for agreeing with this subject).

Conjunct C, in other words, is like Independent C in having a ϕ -probe, but unlike it in preferring ϕ -agreement with wh-phrases when possible. We could view this as a straightforward morphological preference, not unlike the kinds of preferences we often find in agreement systems for agreement with nominals with particular values for [Person] or [Number]¹³. In this particular case, we expect C to have several sets of phi-features available to it given the conditions on locality described in this paper, and its choice among them is dictated by a preference for agreement with wh-phrases.

Other aspects of the behavior of Conjunct C give us evidence, however, that the preference for agreement with wh-phrases can seem to override the locality restrictions discussed above. Bruening (2001, 208) gives a relevant example, involving a relative clause:

¹³ Given the literature on Anti-agreement (Ouhalla 1993, Baier 2017, 2018, and much other work), it is interesting to find a system in which ϕ -agreement with wh-phrases is actually preferred.

(33) N-muhsal-a wot skitap

1-like_{TA}-3OBJ this.AN man

[Piyel ito-k-**il** elitahasi-c-**il** kisi-komutonom-ihc-**il**]

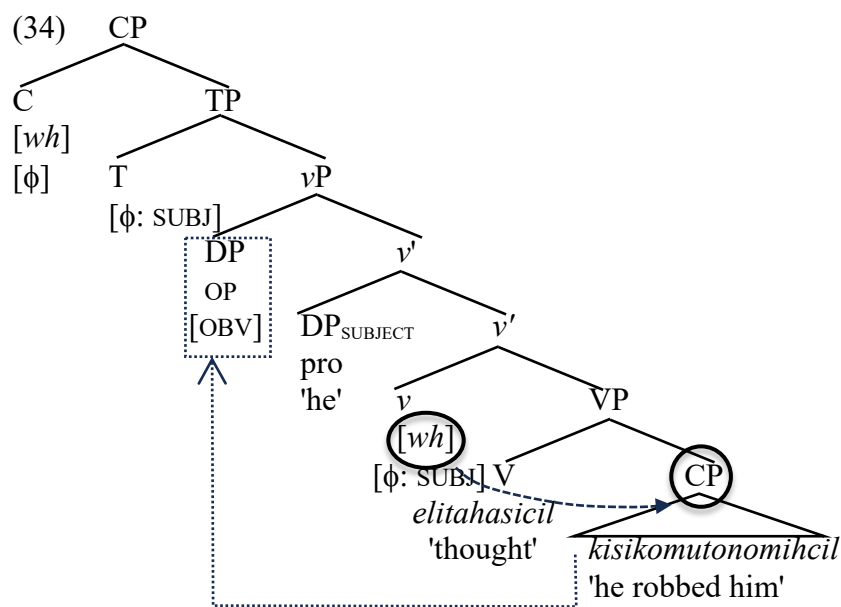
Piyel say_{TI-O}-3CJ-OBV IC.think_{AI}-3CJ-OBV PERF-steal.from-INV.CJ-OBV

'I like the man [that Piyel said he thought robbed him]'

All three of the verbs in the relative clause in (33) are in the Conjunct form, and they all bear the suffix *-il*, which indicates agreement on C with the null relative operator (which is obviative).

What makes this striking is that both *itokil* 'said' and *elitahasicil* 'thought' are of the class of verbs which do not Agree with their clausal complements. The theory developed here therefore predicts, correctly, that since *v* and T in these clauses cannot ϕ -Agree with the complement clause, they will not be able to ϕ -Agree with the A-bar moved relative operator, either. But the example in (33) shows that the behavior of C is different; it can ϕ -Agree with the relative operator, even though it clearly cannot get the ϕ -features from its complement TP, with which it should be ϕ -Agreeing.

A relevant stage of the derivation is shown in (34), which depicts the bottom two clauses of the relative clause:



At this point in the derivation, the *wh*-probe on *v* has Agreed with the complement CP, Agreeing by proxy with the relative operator and triggering movement of the operator to the edge of *vP*. Since this particular CP is, idiosyncratically, the kind that cannot participate in ϕ -agreement, the ϕ -probe on *v* does not find the CP, and can Agree only with the clause's subject. The ϕ -features of the subject will also appear on T when T's ϕ -probe Agrees with *vP*, and by proxy with the subject (in fact, this is where these ϕ -features will be morphologically expressed, as the suffix *-c* '3rd person' on the verb).

The ϕ -features of the relative operator, in other words, will not appear on *v*, or on T. But we do see them appearing morphologically on C, in apparent defiance of locality.

The first point to establish is that this is a morphological behavior which is specific to Conjunct C. The ϕ -Probe on Independent C, for example, shows no preference for agreement with *wh*-phrases, and cannot ϕ -agree with *wh*-phrases which have not been Agreed with by *v* and T:

(35) Wen-ik kt-olitahas [kesel-ti-c-ik]?

who-PROX.PL 2-think_{AI} IC.love_{TA}-RECIP-3CJ-PROX.PL

‘Who do you think loves each other?’ (Grace Paul, p.c., 2025.4.15)

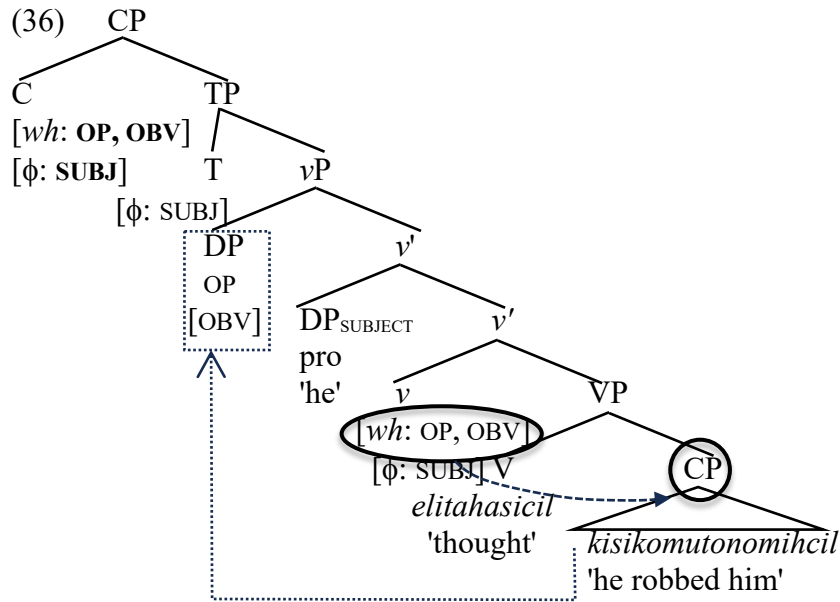
In (35), the verb of the matrix clause is Independent, not Conjunct, and it does not agree with its complement clause. The example therefore ought to have an intermediate stage of derivation much like the one in (34); the *wh*-phrase should be moved by *v*'s *wh*-probe to the edge of *v*P, but the ϕ -Probes of *v* and T should not be able to find the *wh*-phrase, since it is being extracted from a CP with which *v* does not agree. All of this matches the morphological facts; the T and *v* morphemes in (35) are those of an intransitive verb, agreeing only with its subject. But in (35), the Independent version of C cannot reflect the ϕ -features of the *wh*-phrase either. In fact, the ϕ -Probe on matrix C in (35) Agrees with nothing at all; Agreement on C is reserved to 3rd person DPs, as we have seen, and in (35), there are no 3rd person DPs visible to C (the subject is not 3rd person, and the complement clause and the *wh*-phrase are both invisible).

Conjunct C and Independent C are therefore showing distinct morphological behaviors. There are at least two ways that we could try to address this fact.

On one view, the morphological fact about Conjunct C, that it preferentially Agrees morphologically with *wh*-phrases, corresponds to a syntactic fact about the Probes on C; they are entitled to search 'together', finding the closest Goal which satisfies both of their needs. In the case in (33), the [*wh*] and [ϕ] Probes on C may search for a Goal bearing both [*wh*] and [ϕ], even if this means skipping closer potential Goals for [ϕ]. Moreover, this capacity is limited to Conjunct C; Independent C, though it demonstrably has both a *wh*-Probe and a ϕ -Probe, cannot allow them to 'search together' in this way.

Another conceivable kind of approach would give every instance of C the same syntactic properties; on this approach, we would avoid any reference in the syntax to the morphological preferences of Conjunct C, or any special arrangement between this particular pair of Probes. Having given every instance of C the same syntactic properties, we would derive the distinctions between Conjunct and Independent C postsyntactically, in the component of the grammar which is responsible for the morphology. I will sketch an alternative of this kind below.

Suppose we allow wh-probes (or possibly probes, more generally) to be *featurally coarse* in something like the sense of Preminger (2014), Hammerly (2020), and Grishin (2023b): the wh-probe copies from the Goal, not only the wh-feature which it seeks, but all the features of the Goal, including its ϕ -features. The next step in the derivation pictured in (34), on this view, would be Agree relations for the Probes on C which would create the following representation:



In (36), both of the Probes on C have Agreed with their closest possible targets. For the ϕ -Probe, this is the TP, from which C acquires the features of the subject, as usual. C's wh-Probe has found the vP , and has Agreed by proxy with the wh-phrase in the specifier of vP , acquiring not only its wh-features but (thanks to *morphological coarseness*) its obviative ϕ -feature as well.

Giving Agreement this syntactic property allows the distinction between Conjunct and Independent C to be entirely morphological. The morphological realization of Independent C considers only the results of the ϕ -Probe, and agrees morphologically with the structurally lowest 3rd person DP in that set. For Conjunct C, on the other hand, we are to consider only the results of the *wh*-Probe, and realize the ϕ -features on this Probe morphologically.

4. On the propriety of improper movement

The theory developed here has derived certain restrictions on A-movement in languages like English; in particular, A-movement cannot escape CP, and improper movement is banned. These have been portrayed as consequences of the fact that English C lacks a ϕ -Probe; a phrase moved to the edge of CP in English will be invisible to any ϕ -Probes in the higher clause.

At the same time, we have seen evidence that Passamaquoddy C does bear a ϕ -Probe. What does this predict about A-movement out of CP in Passamaquoddy?

To answer this question, we will first need to determine which positions are A-positions in Passamaquoddy. Bruening (2001) establishes, first of all, that the specifier of CP is not an A-position in Passamaquoddy, despite being associated with a ϕ -Probe, because Passamaquoddy *wh*-movement exhibits weak crossover effects:

(37) *Keqsey [not kisihta-q] napsqahma-t?

what that.AN make_{TI-3CJ} trip.over_{AI+O-3CJ}

'What_i did [the one who made it_i] trip over __ ?' [Bruening 2001, 134]

Passamaquoddy C apparently has both a ϕ -Probe and a *wh*-Probe, and it is the latter probe that determines the nature of the specifier of CP as an A-bar position (for discussion of this kind of interaction between multiple probes on a single head, see Lohninger 2025).

(38) Wen pihce w-itapihi-l nekol-ih kcihku-k?
who long.ago 3-friend-OBV IC.leave.behind-INV.CJ forest-LOC

In (38), the verb is in the Inverse form, and there is no weak crossover effect. Bruening proposes that the Inverse involves A-movement of the object to a position above the subject. In (37), by contrast, the verb is not Inverse, and weak crossover therefore arises. I will refer readers to work by others (including Bruening (2001), Grishin (2023a), and Oxford (2024)) for discussion of the conditions under which Inverse appears, but one such condition is the one exhibited in (38), in which the subject and object are both 3rd person and the subject is Obviative (and the object is not).

39

Bruening (2001, 274) reports examples which seem to indicate that Passamaquoddy does indeed allow A-movement out of embedded clauses into matrix clauses:

- (39) Psite wen ' -kosiciy-uku-l w-ikuwoss-ol
 every someone 3-know_{TA}-INV-OBV 3-mother-OBV
 [etoli-koti-peciya-t etolonukahk]
 IC.there-FUT-come_{AI}-3CJ gathering

'Everyone_i, his_i mother knows [that __ is coming to the gathering]'

In (39), the quantifier *psite wen* 'everyone' appears to have moved out of the embedded clause and into the matrix clause. Since this embedded clause is of the type which the matrix verb agrees with, the matrix verb is compelled to agree with the extracted quantifier, and the upshot is that the matrix verb is in the Inverse form (because the subject is Obviative, and the quantifier is not). Crucially, the resulting sentence exhibits no weak crossover effect.

One possible interpretation of examples like (39), then, would be that Passamaquoddy does in fact exhibit a type of licit improper movement. On this interpretation, the quantifier in (39) has begun the derivation in an A-position in the embedded clause, moved out of the embedded clause through its edge (which, as we have seen, is an A-bar position), and is now in the A-position associated with the Inverse form of the verb.

Bruening (2001, 2009) argues against this interpretation of examples like (39), however. His proposal is that (39) involves base-generation of the quantifier in a proleptic position in the matrix clause, related via whatever mechanisms condition prolepsis to a null pronoun in the embedded clause. As we will see, it is important for him that prolepsis is possible in Passamaquoddy only when the matrix verb is in the Inverse form; ordinary displacement, he

says, must indeed involve true movement out of the embedded clause. He offers two arguments for this proposal.

The first is that just when the matrix verb is Inverse, the apparently raised DP can be pronounced in both clauses (Bruening 2001, 276):

- (40) **Petak** '-koscicy-uku-' w-itap-ihī [eli Mali kis-ankuwehta-q
 Petak 3-know_{TA}-INV-OBV.PL 3-friend-OBV.PL IC.C Mali PFV-sell_{TI}-3CJ
 nabsahqehakon **Petak** mil-a-t-pon]
 ring Petak IC.give_{TA+O}-3OBJ-3CJ-PRET

'(As for) Petak, his friends know that Mary sold the ring that Petak gave her'

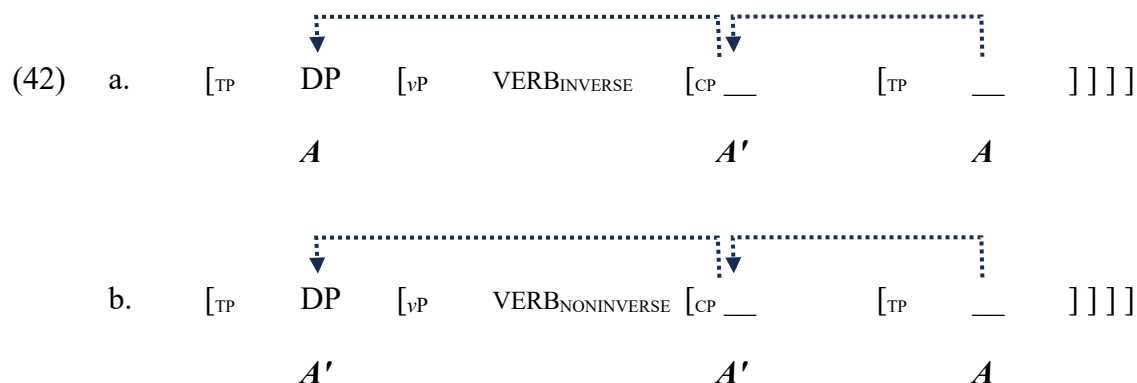
The second is that island effects, which generally apply to movement out of embedded clauses, will disappear if the matrix verb is Inverse (Bruening 2001, 276, 266):

- (41) a. **Tihtiyas kosona Sapet** '-koscicy-uku-l w-ikuwoss-ol
 Tihtiyas or Sapet 3-know_{TA}-INV-OBV 3-mother-OBV
 [eli psite wen macehe [kisi-ntu-htit]
 IC.C every someone leave_{AI}.3 PFV-sing-3PL.CJ
 'Tihtiyas or Sapet, her mother knows that everyone left when __ started singing'
- b. * N-piluwitaham-a **kukec** [eli not skitap nipa-kotunke
 1-suspect_{TA}-DIR warden IC.C that man night-hunt_{AI}.3
 [eci oliya-t Kelis-k]]
 when go_{AI}-3CJ Calais-LOC
 'The warden, I suspect that that man poaches when __ goes to Calais'

In (41a), the verb is Inverse, and the fronted phrase *Tihtiyas kosona Sapet* 'Tihtiyas or Sapet' may be related to its apparent gap across an island boundary. In (41b), the verb is not Inverse, and the relation between *kukec* 'warden' and its apparent gap is subject to island effects.

Bruening therefore concludes that just when the matrix verb is Inverse, apparent cases of movement out of the embedded clause are not movement at all, but prolepsis. He is left with a puzzling stipulation about the nature of prolepsis in Passamaquoddy; it has to be limited to clauses in which the verb is in the Inverse form.

Thanks to Bruening's observations about the distribution of A-positions in Passamaquoddy, the approach to movement developed in this paper gives cross-clausal movement into clauses with Inverse verbs a different kind of special status. If we follow Bruening as regarding Inverse verbs as triggering movement to an A-position above the subject, then just when a DP moves out of a CP into a clause with an Inverse verb, it is performing improper movement. The DP leaves an A-position behind in the embedded clause, travels through the specifier of CP (which is an A-bar position), and lands in Bruening's high A-position (the specifier of TP) with which Inverse is associated. If the higher verb is not Inverse, following Bruening, the specifier of matrix TP is filled by the matrix subject; any movement into the higher clause is therefore to an A-bar position:



In English, the movement chain in (42a) would be impossible, but in Passamaquoddy, thanks to the ϕ -Probe on C, this particular type of improper movement should be available. Can Bruening's observations about the special properties of 'fronting' into clauses with Inverse verbs be made to follow from the contrast in (42)?

If we suppose, contra Bruening, that all of the relevant examples involve movement, then Bruening's observations about the conditions under which a moved phrase can be 'doubled' become observations about the conditions on pronunciation of multiple positions in a movement chain in Passamaquoddy. In particular, any conditions with the following consequence would capture Bruening's observations, it seems to me:

- (43) a. Let a *complete A-chain* be the maximal set of A-positions in a movement chain which are not interrupted by any A-bar positions.
- b. Every complete A-chain in Passamaquoddy may be associated with a pronounced nominal.

The conditions in (43) distinguish the cases in (42). The movement in (42a) creates two complete A-chains, separated by an intervening A-bar position, and can therefore have two pronounced positions. In the movement in (42b), by contrast, there is only a single complete A-chain.

If something like (43) can be maintained, then it seems to me that it might help us understand Bruening's second observation, as well; the movement in (42a), which ends in a clause with an Inverse verb, is immune to island effects, while the movement in (42b) is not. Movements creating chains with multiple pronounced copies often seem to be immune to island effects; this is at least one popular approach to the phenomenon of resumptive pronouns. And since Passamaquoddy pronouns are often null, we should expect its resumptive pronouns to be

capable of being null as well. On this view, examples like (41a) are well-formed because the lower complete A-chain created by the movement chain can be realized as a (null) resumptive pronoun, obviating the effect of the island. In (41b), since movement is of the more conventional type which creates only a single A-chain, no resumptive pronoun is possible, and movement is constrained by the island effect.

I began this section by observing that the theory developed here, although it blocks improper movement in English, would allow certain kinds of improper movement in Passamaquoddy. Following Bruening's (2001) observations about the distribution of A-positions in Passamaquoddy, we expect improper movement to be limited to movement into a clause containing a verb in the Inverse form. Bruening (2001) in fact reports facts that could be taken as vindicating this prediction; cross-clausal movement does show signs of being able to land in an A-position in the matrix clause (judging from the distribution of weak crossover effects), just when the matrix verb is Inverse. Bruening (2001) argues against a movement analysis of the relevant data, showing several ways in which the dependencies in question are unlike conventional cases of movement, and proposing instead that Passamaquoddy has a type of proleptic construction which is (mysteriously) limited to clauses with Inverse verbs. I have sketched an alternative, in which Bruening's observations about the special properties of the relevant movements are discoveries about the nature of well-formed improper movement, rather than being arguments against a movement analysis. On the alternative view, no mysterious conditions on prolepsis need to be posited.

5. Generalizations

The preceding discussion has developed a theory of the ban on improper movement, and of phase unlocking, and also of some complex facts about agreement in Passamaquoddy. It has made some crucial assumptions about locality, and about the nature of Agree relations.

5.1 Locality

It has been useful to say that T, in both Passamaquoddy and English, bears a ϕ -probe that is very local: it can Agree just with a ϕ -bearing XP such that no other ϕ -bearing YP is c-commanded by the Probe-bearing head and either dominates or c-commands XP. In other words, the ϕ -probe on T is subject to something like Relativized Minimality (Rizzi 1990) or its successors. The upshot of this has been that T can Agree only with DPs with which vP has already Agreed; since vP itself bears the ϕ -features which have Agreed with the DPs in the clause, any DPs inside vP are not accessible to T. This was important for the derivation of the ban on improper movement, and for facts about agreement in Passamaquoddy (for example, the fact that Passamaquoddy T can Agree with embedded clauses, or participate in long-distance agreement into those clauses, or agree with extracted wh-phrases, just if v can).

We have also seen that v , in both English and Passamaquoddy, cannot Probe into the interior of an embedded CP; this is why wh-extraction from a clausal complement requires Agree between v and the embedded CP (the phenomenon of ‘phase unlocking’), allowing v to Agree with the wh-phrase by proxy, and it is also why a ϕ -probe on v cannot Agree with an embedded wh-phrase unless it can also Agree with the embedding CP (as Passamaquoddy shows), and unless the embedded C has a ϕ -probe Agreeing with the wh-phrase (which is why Passamaquoddy, but not English, allows ϕ -Agree between v and an extracted wh-phrase).

Ultimately, in the approach developed here, the opacity of CP had to do with the fact that CP is

itself a possible target for ϕ -probing, bearing a ϕ -feature of its own. In principle, if there are languages in which CP lacks a ϕ -feature of its own, we would such a CP to be transparent to higher ϕ -probes.

A core claim of the paper has been that all of these conditions on locality may appear to be circumvented, thanks to the phenomenon of Agreement by proxy. CP, for example, may be generally opaque to probing, but any features on C which C has acquired via Agree are in principle accessible to higher Probes.

Despite the reference to the descriptive phenomenon of 'phase unlocking', I have not needed to make any crucial appeal to phases. The phenomena in question appear to reduce entirely to classic conditions on locality, of the type represented by Relativized Minimality and its descendants.

5.2 Agree

This paper has made some crucial assumptions about the nature of Agree, which I'll now try to discuss explicitly. I think it is fairly widely agreed that agreement morphology is the outcome of (at least) two kinds of processes:

- (44) a. Syntactic probe-goal operations
- b. Morphological operations which determine how the features gathered in (30a) are to be morphologically exponed.

There is a great deal of exciting current work on complex agreement systems (Béjar 2003, Deal 2015, and much other work), some of it dealing with agreement that seems to prefer particular kinds of ϕ -features. Much of this work, I think, assigns this kind of preference to the operations in (44a), positing ϕ -probes which specifically look for features like [plural] or [participant].

In fact, Passamaquoddy is one of the kinds of languages which are commonly analyzed in this way. Passamaquoddy has agreement prefixes, for example, which preferentially agree with 2nd person arguments:

- (45) a. K-mihqitaham-a
 2-remember_{TA}-3OBJ
 ‘You remember him/her’
- b. K-mihqitaham-oq
 2-remember_{TA}-INV
 ‘He/she remembers you’
- c. K-mihqitaham-ol
 2-remember_{TA}-2OBJ
 ‘I remember you’
- d. K-mihqitaham-i
 2-remember_{TA}-1OBJ
 ‘You remember me’

The prefix *k-* ‘2’ appears in all of these examples, regardless of whether the 2nd person DP is the subject or the object.

This prefix is generally held to be generated in T. But it has been important in the account developed above that T is not at all ‘choosy’ in what it agrees with; it agrees with all the DPs in the clause by proxy, via its direct Agree relation with *v*P. If we allow T to Probe the interior of *v*P, all the results described here will be lost (in particular, there will be no way to prevent T from finding *wh*-phrases which have moved to the edge of *v*P but have not participated in ϕ -Agreement with *v*).

It will be important for this account, then, that conditions like ‘prefer to expone morphological agreement with a 2nd person DP, if one is present’ are not part of the makeup of the syntactic probe itself, but rather part of the conditions on exponence of the features gathered in the narrow syntax by the ϕ -probe on T. In other words, the preference for agreement with 2nd person DPs is part of (44b), rather than (44a).

In section 3.3 above I addressed another condition of a similar kind; we saw that Passamaquoddy has a particular type of C (the Conjunct version of C) which preferentially Agrees with the ϕ -features of *wh*-phrases, and which seems to be capable of violating the general locality restrictions on ϕ -agreement in order to do so. I proposed an approach to the phenomenon that made crucial use of *coarseness*; *wh*-Probes very generally copy not only the feature [*wh*] but also the ϕ -features of their Goal, and what distinguishes Conjunct C is a postsyntactic preference to morphologically realized ϕ -features which are gathered by *wh*-Probes. Instances of Independent C (and, for that matter, T and *v*), on the other hand, realize ϕ -features gathered by ϕ -probes.

An upshot of this approach to Agree is that the syntactic behavior of probes is quite uniform; every probe Agrees with, and copies (coarsely) the features of, every Goal in its search domain. Every search domain, moreover, is relatively small, consisting just of the closest potential Goals (with ‘closest’ defined, in a familiar way, so that when two Goals are c-commanded by a Probe, a Goal X is closer than a Goal Y if X dominates or c-commands Y).

On this picture of Agree, we can see Agree as a way of creating, in the narrow syntax, bundles of information about the hierarchical relations between certain nodes. We could think of Agree as the way that the computation ‘looks at the tree’ and determines which nodes c-command which other nodes. Perhaps this information is then put to use when the computation must make

reference to relative c-command relations (for example, in computations of linearization, or of scope).

6. Conclusions

This paper has presented new accounts of the ban on improper movement, 'phase unlocking', and the conditions on agreement in Passamaquoddy. These accounts are available to us on the generalizations about locality and the nature of agreement just reviewed, along with the following generalization:

(46) *Agreement by Proxy is Agreement*

The syntactic and morphological consequences of a Probe-Goal relation between X and Y can take place if X Agrees with Y either *directly* or *by proxy*.

References

- Baier, Nico. 2017. Antilocality and antiagreement. *Linguistic Inquiry* 48.367-377.
- Baier, Nico. 2018. *Anti-agreement*. Doctoral thesis. University of California, Berkeley.
- Baker, Mark. 1988. *Incorporation: a theory of grammatical function changing*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.
- Béjar, Susana. 2003. *Phi-syntax: a theory of agreement*. Doctoral thesis. University of Toronto.
- Béjar, Susana, and Milan Rezac. 2009. Cyclic agree. *Linguistic Inquiry* 40.35-73.
- Bhatt, Rajesh. 2005. Long distance agreement in Hindi-Urdu. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory* 23.757-807.
- Bhatt, Rajesh, and Stefan Keine. 2017. Long-distance agreement. In: Martin Everaert and Henk van Riemsdijk, editors. *The Wiley Blackwell Companion to Syntax*. Hoboken, NJ: John Wiley and Sons, Inc. 2291-2321.
- Bobaljik, Jonathan, and Susi Wurmbrand. 2005. The domain of agreement. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory* 23.809-865.
- Branigan, Philip, and Marguerite MacKenzie. 2001. How much syntax can you fit into a word? Late insertion and verbal agreement in Innu-aimûn. In: Suzanne Gessner, Sunyoung Oh, and Kayono Shiobara, editors. *Proceedings of WSCLA 5*. Vancouver, BC: UBC Working Papers in Linguistics, Vancouver, BC. 37-52.
- Bruening, Benjamin. 2001. *Syntax at the edge: cross-clausal phenomena and the syntax of Passamaquoddy*. Doctoral thesis. MIT.
- Bruening, Benjamin. 2009. Algonquian languages have A-movement and A-agreement. *Linguistic Inquiry* 40.427-445.
- Chomsky, Noam. 1973. Conditions on transformations. In: Stephen Anderson and Paul Kiparsky, editors. *A festschrift for Morris Halle*. New York: Holt, Rinehart and Winston. 232-286.
- Chomsky, Noam. 1981. *Lectures on government and binding*. Dordrecht: Foris.
- Chomsky, Noam. 2000. Minimalist inquiries: the framework. In: Roger Martin, David Michaels, and Juan Uriagereka, editors. *Step by step: essays on Minimalist syntax in honor of Howard Lasnik*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press. 89-156.
- Chomsky, Noam. 2001. Derivation by phase. In: Michael Kenstowicz, editor. *Ken Hale: a life in language*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press. 1-52.
- Clem, Emily, and Amy Rose Deal. 2024. Dependent Case by Agree: ergative in Shawi. *Linguistic Inquiry* 57.267-313.
- Deal, Amy Rose. 2015. Interaction and satisfaction in ϕ -agreement. In: Thuy Bui and Deniz Özyıldız, editors. *Proceedings of NELS 45*. Amherst, MA: GLSA. 179-192.
- Fong, Suzana. 2019. Proper movement through Spec-CP: an argument from hyperraising in Mongolian. *Glossa* 4(1):30. doi: <https://doi.org/10.5334/gigl.667>
- Grishin, Peter. 2023a. *Lessons in CP from Passamaquoddy and beyond*. Doctoral thesis. MIT.
- Grishin, Peter. 2023b. Omnivorous third person agreement in Algonquian. *Glossa* 8(1). doi: <https://doi.org/10.16995/glossa.8874>
- Grishin, Peter. To appear. How to agree with the lowest DP. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory*.
- Halpert, Claire. 2019. Raising, unphased. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory* 37.123-165.
- Hammerly, Christopher. 2020. *Person-based prominence in Ojibwe*. Doctoral thesis. University of Massachusetts, Amherst.

- Hedding, Andrew, and Michelle Yuan. 2023. Phase unlocking and the derivation of verb-initiality in San Martín Peras Mixtec. In Nikolas Webster, Yağmur Kiper, Richard Wang, and Sichen Larry Lyu, editors. *Proceedings of the 41st West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics*. Somerville, MA: Cascadilla Proceedings Project. 184-193.
- Lee, Tommy Tsz-Ming, and Ka-Fai Yip. 2021. Raising, phase unlocked. In Rachel Soo, una Y. Chow, and Sander Nederveen, editors. *Proceedings of the 38th West Coast Conference on Formal Linguistics*. Somerville, MA: Cascadilla Proceedings Project. 274-282.
- LeSourd, Philip. 2018. Raising and long-distance agreement in Passamaquoddy: a unified analysis. *Journal of Linguistics* 55.357-405.
- Lohninger, Magdalena. 2025. *Patterns in chaos: composite A'/A probes*. Doctoral thesis. University of Vienna.
- Mahajan, Anoop. 1989. Agreement and agreement phrases. In Itziar Laka and Anoop Mahajan, editors. *MITWPL 10: Functional Heads and Clause Structure*. Cambridge, MA: MITWPL. 217-252.
- Ouhalla, Jamal. 1993. Subject-extraction, negation, and the anti-agreement effect. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory* 11.477-518.
- Oxford, Will. 2024. *The Algonquian Inverse*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Polinsky, Masha, and Eric Potsdam. 2001. Long-distance agreement and topic in Tsez. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory* 19.583-646.
- Poole, Ethan. 2024. Dependent-case assignment could be AGREE. *Glossa* 9(1). doi: <https://doi.org/10.16995/glossa.9894>
- Preminger, Omer. 2011. Asymmetries between person and number in syntax: a commentary on Baker's SCOPA. *Natural Language and Linguistic Theory* 29.917-937.
- Preminger, Omer. 2014. *Agreement and its failures*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
- Rackowski, Andrea, and Norvin Richards. 2005. Phase edge and extraction: a Tagalog case study. *Linguistic Inquiry* 36.565-599.
- Richards, Norvin. 1997. *What moves where when in which language?* Doctoral thesis. MIT.
- Richards, Norvin. 2026. Long-distance agreement by proxy in Passamaquoddy-Wolastoqey. Talk given at WCCFL 44, Universidad Nacional Autónoma de México (UNAM).
- Rizzi, Luigi. 1990. *Relativized Minimality*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
- Thivierge, Sigwan. 2021. *Phasehood and phi-intervention*. Doctoral thesis. University of Maryland.
- van Urk, Coppe. 2015. *A uniform syntax for phrasal movement: a case study of Dinka Bor*. Doctoral thesis. MIT.
- van Urk, Coppe, and Norvin Richards. 2015. Two components of long-distance extraction: successive cyclicity in Dinka. *Linguistic Inquiry* 46.113-155.